

Each member has one vote, and it takes nine votes to decide a policy. All members are obliged to abide by the council's rulings, but there is a crucial exception. At Yalta, Stalin insisted that each of the five permanent members had the power of veto. Roosevelt was reluctant to accept this at first, but it did fix a fatal flaw of the League of Nations, which could theoretically order its members to act in defiance of their own governments.

The veto remains a bone of contention. In the 1950s and '60s, the US had so much global influence that it never had to use the veto, but council decisions were continually blocked by the USSR, especially Andrei Gromyko, whose frequent vetoes earned him the nickname Mr. Nyet (Mr. No). More recently, the US has used its veto to block any resolutions on the Israeli–Palestinian conflict. There has been much criticism of

Armored UN vehicles accompany Congolese people fleeing from Kibumba Internally Displaced Persons camp following an outbreak of violence in 2008 between rival political factions.

the Security Council's membership. In particular, the dominance of the five original permanent members, the P5, is seen as outmoded, reflecting the global politics of 1945 rather than today. Other countries, such as Brazil, Germany, India, and Japan (the so-called G4), have campaigned to be given permanent membership.

Peacekeeping

The Security Council's principal task is to maintain international peace. While it has achieved some success, most notably in El Salvador and Mozambique, its efforts to keep peace in Syria have been a conspicuous failure.

The creators of the UN realized that, without any armed forces, the League of Nations was unable to intervene effectively to keep the peace even in minor disputes. Consequently, the Security Council was quick to set up multinational peacekeeping forces. The first was deployed to oversee the ceasefire during the 1948 Arab–Israeli War in Palestine. They were intended to act as police forces, only ever responding with weapons in self-

There is no alternative to the UN. It is still the last best hope of humanity.

Kofi Annan

UN secretary general (1997–2006)

defense. Over the decades, these ad hoc international forces became more fully established, especially after 1992, when the United Nations Department of Peacekeeping Operations (DPO) was set up. Now they are a key part of the UN, but there is no standing army or permanent structure; the peacekeeping force is assembled afresh for each mission.

The Court of Justice

One of the key bodies carried over to the UN from the League of Nations was the Permanent Court of International Justice. The PCIJ's UN successor, the International Court of Justice (ICJ, or World Court) was set up in San Francisco in 1945. Unlike the UN, which had to find a new home in New York, the ICJ already had one at The Hague, in the Netherlands.

The ICJ's purpose is to settle disputes between nation-states, but cases can only go ahead when the states involved consent to the Court having jurisdiction to consider the dispute. After the ICJ ruled in 1986 that the United States' covert war against Nicaragua was a violation of international law, the US withdrew its consent and agreed only to recognize the Court's

